MEMO

To: Director, Medicaid Contact Center Operations (Florida)

From: Juan Villegas, Villegas Analytics

Date: November 12, 2026

Re: Call-center access during Medicaid unwinding: findings and recommendations

Bottom line

During unwinding (March 2023 – July 2024), Florida's Medicaid call center was **one of the hardest in the country to reach.** Callers waited **about 31 minutes** on average, which is **twice the national average and five times the other large states. 37% hung up** before reaching anyone: about **13.4 million calls**. Florida ranked **3rd worst of 50 reporting states**, and its wait was over 15 minutes in **all 17 months**. Access improved in 2024, but not enough to close the gap. The fix is to staff to the renewal calendar, cut avoidable calls, and manage the queue with weekly targets.

What the data shows

Measure (Mar 2023 – Jul 2024)	Florida	National	Large-state peers (TX, CA, NY, GA, PA)
Weighted average wait	**30.8 min**	14.4 min	6.3 min
Callers who hung up	**37.4%**	18.4%	10.7%
Total calls	35.8 million (23% of U.S.)	154.7 million	41.6 million
Months with wait over 15 minutes	**17 of 17**	—	—
Rank (1 = worst access, risk score)	**3 of 50**	—	—

1. **The problem was constant, not a one-month spike.** Florida ranked between 2nd and 8th worst every month. Its worst months were November 2023 (42 minutes, 44% hung up), July 2023 (41 minutes, 43%) and April 2023 (40 minutes, 50%).
2. **Florida carried the heaviest call load in the country:** 487 calls per 1,000 enrollees per month, against 314 for the next-highest state (Utah). Volume peaked at **2.6 million calls in January 2024**.
3. **Calls followed renewals.** Nationally, monthly call volume and renewals due moved together (correlation 0.94). Peaks were predictable from the renewal calendar.
4. **Some improvement in 2024.** Florida's weighted wait fell from 34.1 minutes (2023) to 26.7 minutes (Jan–Jul 2024), and hang-ups fell from 39.2% to 35.1%. It was still about twice the national level (12.6 minutes in 2024).
5. **Other states show recovery is possible.** Maine went from a 44-minute peak to under 6 minutes, Oklahoma from 46 to under 10, and Idaho from 56 to under 19.
6. **Context:** Florida's enrollment fell from 5.09 million to 3.80 million over the period. Procedural (paperwork-related) terminations were about 22% of renewals due in Florida. Across states, phone access and procedural terminations were only weakly related (correlation 0.13), so long waits alone do not explain terminations.

Recommendations

1. **Staff to the renewal calendar.** Calls track renewals almost one-to-one, so forecast weekly call volume from the number of renewals due and schedule agents 4–6 weeks ahead of each renewal wave. Add temporary or vendor capacity for the peak months.
2. **Cut avoidable calls.** Expand automatic (ex parte) renewals, send plain-language renewal notices with clear deadlines, and add self-service status checks (web, text and IVR) so people don't need an agent to ask "did you get my paperwork?"

3. **Stop losing callers in the queue.** Offer a scheduled or virtual callback once the wait passes 10 minutes, and publish an expected-wait message at the start of the call.
4. **Manage to weekly targets.** Track average wait, abandonment rate and calls per 1,000 enrollees every week, with clear thresholds (for example, wait under 15 minutes and abandonment under 15%) and a named owner for each.
5. **Learn from recovered states.** Contact Maine, Oklahoma and Idaho to find out which changes cut their waits so quickly.

Limits of this analysis

- States define "call center" differently, so comparisons show broad patterns, not exact rankings.
- Wait times are whole-minute monthly averages and hide the range of individual waits.
- South Dakota has no call center and is excluded; some states changed how they counted calls (Rhode Island, Hawaii, Arizona).
- These findings describe patterns, not causes.

Data and method: CMS Medicaid and CHIP CAA Reporting Metrics (October 2024 release) and the Performance Indicator dataset (March 2026 release). Totals reconcile across Python, SQL and Excel (867 state-months, 154,681,330 calls, 28,472,216 abandoned calls). Live dashboard: https://medicaid-access-monitor.streamlit.app/